

Dating Through the Divide: How Political Identity Influences Romantic Partner Selection in a
Polarized Society

by

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Abstract

This study examines how political identity influences romantic partner preferences in the context of growing political polarization in the United States. Drawing on Byrne's Similarity and Liking Hypothesis and Tajfel and Turner's Social Identity Theory, the research investigates the role of political identity, stereotypes, and priming in shaping attraction. Specifically, it tests whether biases could be reduced by priming counter-stereotypical messages that suggest polarization is not as intense as many believe. A between-subjects experimental design was employed, with participants randomly assigned to one of three priming conditions before evaluating mock dating profiles labeled as Democrat, Republican, or Independent, and responding to questions about their willingness to date people from the other political side. The study tested whether political alignment increases attraction, whether stereotypical and polarizing priming intensifies political bias, and whether counter-stereotypical priming reduces bias in partner selection. Results suggest that counter-stereotypical priming may reduce gaps in evaluation of one's own party and the opposing party, compared to control. Other effects were not significant, though the sample for analyses was small ($N = 67$) due to quality issues. Future research is needed to fully understand the potential of the intervention to reduce political biases in dating.

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Introduction

Growing political polarization in the United States has occupied not only public discussion and policymaking but also interpersonal and romantic aspects of social life. Affective polarization, the phenomenon where individuals hold increasingly negative feelings toward members of opposing political parties, has been correlated with many factors that may amplify societal division (Iyengar et al., 2019). Political identity has been one of many facets shaping interpersonal relationships throughout history, but in the contemporary era, it has emerged as a marker of social belonging and identity (Mason, 2018). In the realm of interpersonal relationships, for example, a 2020 survey showed that citizens identifying with both parties expressed concerns about their kids marrying a person from the other party. Specifically, about 38% of Democrats and Republicans were reported feeling very or somewhat upset about such scenario¹. Such negative emotions could lead to political tensions, intolerance and suspicion (Levendusky et al., 2024), polarization, misinformation (Ophir et al., 2024) and even violence (Kalmoe & Mason, 2022). The growing salience of political identity has significant implications for romantic relationships, as it serves as a signal for compatibility in a domain that has been relatively underexplored in the context of polarization.

Romantic relationships offer a unique viewpoint for understanding the broader consequences of political polarization, as they are one of the most intimate forms of social bonding and a domain where social identity is key in terms of compatibility. Prior research suggests that political alignment can influence partner selection, with individuals increasingly prioritizing shared political beliefs over other traits, such as religion or education (Fangmeier et al., 2020; Klofstad et al., 2013). This trend reflects a societal shift toward social sorting, where individuals seek relationships that reinforce their ideological identities (Mason, 2018). Though

¹ <https://today.yougov.com/society/articles/32171-america-speaks-what-do-they-think-about-cross-part>

shared political identity can enhance relationship compatibility, it may also deepen societal divisions by reducing opportunities for meaningful engagement across ideological and political lines (Buliga et al., 2021).

The current study observes how political identity, stereotypes, and priming influence romantic partner preferences and selection in the United States. Building on past research, it examines how affective polarization influences attraction and explores potential strategies for reducing political biases in partner selection, utilizing literature from similarity and liking as a foundation. Ahler and Sood (2018) consider how misperceptions about political out-group composition significantly contribute to polarization. These misperceptions manifest as stereotypes that frame political opponents in over-simplified and negative terms, making inter-party relationships less likely to occur. This study also explores the intersection of political identity and attraction through two foundational psychological frameworks, Byrne's Similarity and Liking Hypothesis (1971) and Tajfel and Turner's Social Identity Theory (1979). I hypothesize that these stereotypes, when primed, significantly impact how individuals perceive and evaluate potential romantic partners. Since many learn about romantic relationships from the media (Moore & Ophir, 2021) and studies have found that romantic expectations may be shaped by short media texts (Moore et al., 2023), I examine whether exposure to short media texts priming stereotypical and counter-stereotypical messages about political partisans in the US may increase or decrease biases in partner selection.

The findings of such an experiment also contribute to the growing body of research on prejudice reduction by testing the efficacy of counter-stereotypical interventions and debiasing techniques. By adopting frameworks developed in social psychology (Hsieh et al., 2022; Paluck et al., 2021), I seek to understand whether exposing individuals to counter-stereotypical

information, specifically fabricated news articles, about political out-groups can reduce political biases in romantic partner selection. By addressing these gaps, this study aims to provide new insights into the interaction between political polarization and romantic relationships and identify rational strategies for creating an environment for greater ideological tolerance in romantic endeavors.

In sum, the thesis is guided by the following broad research questions:

1. How do political identity and stereotypes influence romantic partner preferences in the United States?
2. What role does priming play in shaping perceptions of politically aligned and misaligned partners?
3. Can counter-stereotypical interventions effectively reduce political biases in romantic partner selection?

By addressing these questions, this study hopes to emphasize the broad-scale implications of political polarization for social cohesion and offer pathways for bridging divides in an era of increasing ideological fragmentation.

Literature Review

The Science Behind Attraction

Byrne's Similarity and Liking Hypothesis (1971) posits that individuals are drawn to others with similar traits, values, and beliefs because such similarity affirms one's worldview and reduces uncertainty. This hypothesis has been replicated across a wide array of social contexts, including studies of romantic relationships, where attitudinal similarity has been found to enhance attraction, liking, and perceived compatibility (Montoya & Horton, 2013). Tidwell

and colleagues (2013) further demonstrated that perceived similarity, even when inaccurate, can significantly influence initial attraction. In the context of the present study, political identity is increasingly used as a shorthand for shared values and moral worldviews, making it a prominent factor in romantic decision-making. Finkel et al. (2020) argue that political identity may now carry more weight than traditional indicators like religious affiliation or educational background in determining partner compatibility.

Social Identity Theory, as proposed by Tajfel and Turner (1979), explains how individuals derive part of their self-concept from group memberships and often evaluate others through the lens of in-group and out-group dynamics. When political identity becomes salient, this framework predicts increased in-group favoritism and out-group derogation. These biases, intensified by our current polarized media landscape (Mason, 2018), can shape not only political attitudes but also perceptions of romantic desirability. Even minimal political cues, such as party affiliation listed on a dating profile, can activate social identity processes that guide partner evaluations (Chen & Rohla, 2018). Similarly, studies found media primes can shape beliefs and attitudes about dating and romantic relationships (Moore et al., 2023).

Research by Iyengar and Westwood (2015) demonstrates that partisanship influences not only political behavior but also decisions in seemingly neutral contexts, such as hiring and award selection. In romantic contexts, this same in-group preference may lead individuals to overlook or avoid potential partners who express political views different from their own. Priming, through exposure to partisan or depolarizing messages, can influence the salience of these identities and the extent to which they influence judgments. Kim and McCombs (2007) outline how priming mechanisms operate by activating stored schemas, and other studies have found that even brief exposure to political content can shift attitudes and behaviors (Paluck et al., 2021;

Hsieh et al., 2022). While negative priming is likely to reinforce division, counter-stereotypical priming may soften bias and foster more inclusive decision-making, prompting individuals to forego their preconceived perceptions of out-group party members.

Affective Polarization and Interpersonal Relationships

Affective polarization is a key framework for understanding the increasing tension and hostility between opposing political groups in the United States. Affective polarization is described as the tendency to view members of opposing political parties with hostility while favoring members of one's own party. It has been extensively documented as a driving force behind societal division (Iyengar et al., 2019). Ahler and Sood (2018) emphasize that misperceptions about political out-groups contribute to exaggerated stereotypes, framing political opponents as fundamentally different and less trustworthy. They demonstrated that while there are objective differences between Republicans and Democrats in the US, partisans tend to overestimate such differences in stereotypical ways. This dynamic creates a significant obstacle in forming inter-party relationships, whether platonic or romantic.

Studies on partner preferences have explored the role of affective polarization in romantic relationships. Klostad et al. (2013) found that political alignment plays a significant role in romantic attraction, with individuals prioritizing shared political beliefs when selecting a partner. This tendency reflects broader patterns of social sorting, where individuals increasingly interact within ideologically similar networks (Mason, 2018; Mutz, 2006). This, in turn, leads to further polarization and politicization of everyday life (Young, 2019) and non-political spaces (Wang, Thimmanayakanapalya, & Ophir, 2024). While the impact of politics on dating and romantic relationships may improve relationship compatibility and reduce potential conflict, it also reinforces societal divisions by limiting exposure to differing perspectives (Buliga et al., 2021).

The Role of Stereotypes and Misperceptions

Stereotypes about political out-groups are a critical device through which affective polarization influences social relationships. As mentioned earlier, Ahler and Sood (2018) exhibit that Americans consistently overestimate the extent to which opposing parties differ in demographic composition and ideological extremity, often viewing members of the opposing party as radicals. These erroneous perceptions dehumanize political opposition, decreasing the likelihood of meaningful engagement across party lines, whether it be a platonic exchange of ideas or romantic efforts. Tsfaty and Nir (2017) further highlight the role of selective exposure in reinforcing these stereotypes, as individuals consume information that aligns with their preexisting beliefs, exacerbating affective polarization and strengthening their intrinsic notions.

In romantic life, stereotypes about political out-groups can significantly impact partner selection. Fangmeier et al. (2020) found that individuals who perceive political opponents as ethically or intellectually inferior are less likely to consider them serious romantic partners. Commonly shaped by media narratives and social opinions, these stereotypes create barriers to bridging ideological divides in personal relationships.

Priming and Interpersonal Attraction

Priming plays a crucial role in shaping how individuals evaluate potential romantic partners. Often studied along the related but separate process of agenda setting and framing (Scheufele, & Tewksbury, 2007; Walter & Ophir, 2024), priming plays a key role in understanding media effects. While agenda setting focuses on the salience of topics, and framing on how the media highlights specific aspects of events, priming effects are the result of the media making some information more accessible. As explained by Scheufele & Tewksbury (2007), priming effects occur “when news content suggests to news audiences that they ought to

use specific issues as benchmarks” for evaluation of people or events (p. 11). Research on priming effects suggests that exposure to political signals and indications can trigger stereotypes and biases, influencing the decision-making processes (Kim & McCombs, 2007). Political priming may lead individuals to overvalue (or underplay) ideological compatibility in romantic relationships, even at the expense of other important traits, such as shared morals or an emotional connection. This phenomenon shows the potential influence of political identity in shaping personal preferences and behaviors within relationships and the role media coverage of polarization may play in shaping it.

Strategies for Reducing Political Biases

Given the significant impact of political identity on interpersonal relationships, researchers have focused on constructing strategies for reducing biases and promoting ideological tolerance across political lines. Counter-stereotypical interventions expose individuals to information that challenges their preexisting notions, often stereotypical, and show potential for reducing polarization. Hsieh et al. (2022) conducted a meta-analysis of prejudice reduction experiments, finding that interventions emphasizing group commonalities were particularly effective in reducing biases. Similarly, Paluck et al. (2021) emphasize the potential of exposure to counter-stereotypical narratives in challenging negative perceptions of out-groups, a finding that could significantly alter perceptions of opposing political others.

Interventions in romantic relationships could involve showing individuals examples of successful cross-party relationships or emphasizing shared values that exceed political differences. Buliga et al. (2021) suggest that nurturing intergroup interaction through friendships or romantic partnerships can reduce prejudice and stereotyping by humanizing political opponents. Importantly, prior research demonstrated that showing participants news reports on

romantic relationships may change their beliefs and attitudes around partners and romantic interactions (Moore et al., 2023). Together, these studies provide a promising foundation for developing interventions to mitigate political biases in partner selection.

While existing research has described the relationship between political identity and interpersonal dynamics, gaps remain. Particularly needed are studies that directly examine the interaction between political priming, stereotypes, and romantic attraction. Additionally, while the effectiveness of counter-stereotypical interventions has been shown in broader scenarios, their application to romantic relationships is underexplored. This study seeks to address these gaps by investigating how political identity influences romantic partner preferences and testing the effectiveness of prejudice reduction strategies in this realm.

Taken together, I hypothesize that:

H1: Participants will rate politically aligned partners as more attractive and compatible than misaligned partners.

H2: Negative priming will increase political bias in partner selection.

H3: Counter-stereotypical priming will reduce political bias in partner selection.

Methods and Design

Participants and Ethical Considerations

Participants were recruited from a large, public Northeastern university undergraduate subject pool via the Sona System, which offers course credit for research participation. The target sample size was approximately 150 students (roughly 50 per experimental condition) to ensure adequate statistical power for between-group comparisons. Inclusion criteria required that participants be at least 18 years old and fluent in English. Given the study's focus on U.S.

political identity, participants were expected to have familiarity with the U.S. political party system; however, no specific party affiliation was required for enrollment. I anticipated the sample to consist primarily of young adults around 18-22 years old, with a typical gender distribution for the subject pool, often majority female, though all genders were included.

All procedures were approved by the University's Institutional Review Board prior to data collection. Participants provided informed consent at the start of the online survey, after reading an explanation of the study's general purpose, described as an investigation of "dating attitudes and article reading comprehension," to avoid fully revealing the political focus up front. They were informed of their rights to withdraw at any time without penalty and of the minimal risks, no greater than everyday life, aside from possible mild discomfort reflecting on political differences. Participant responses were recorded anonymously; no personally identifying information was collected. At the end of the study, participants were debriefed about the exact purpose of the experiment, namely, examining the influence of political identity priming on dating preferences, and the use of different article stimuli. Any deception by omission was explained, and participants had the opportunity to ask questions or withdraw their data. As a safeguard, the debriefing also provided resources for support in case discussing political or relationship preferences raised any discomfort, though this was not expected. Each participant received appropriate course credit upon completion. Overall, ethical standards of confidentiality, voluntary participation, and informed consent were strictly upheld in line with IRB guidelines and institutional policies.

Research Design

This study employed a between-subjects experimental design with three conditions, combined with a within-subject component for repeated evaluations of dating profiles. The

between-subjects factor was Political Identity Priming, with participants randomly assigned to one of three conditions: a Control condition (a non-political story about national parks), a Polarization Reinforcing prime (a political story emphasizing stereotypical differences between Republicans and Democrats), or a Depolarizing prime (counter-stereotypical, emphasizing commonalities). The prime was delivered in the form of a brief news-style article that participants read. Each participant was exposed to only one of these articles, ensuring independent groups for comparison across the three priming conditions.

After the priming manipulation, all participants, regardless of prime condition, were shown a series of three mock dating profiles. Each participant viewed one profile labeled as a Democrat, one as a Republican, and one as an Independent. The order of presentation of these profiles was randomized for each participant to control for order effects. While the profiles mentioned the political affiliation of the potential partner, other information such as hobbies consisted strictly of non-political information. All profiles were from small towns in the state of New York. Every participant evaluated the same set of profile stimuli, allowing to examine how within-person differences in response to Democrat vs. Republican vs. Independent profiles might depend on the between-person priming condition they viewed.

The structure of the design was originally intended to test both main effects and interactions. First, I expected a main effect of profile political affiliation on dating evaluations, reflecting baseline political preferences. Prior research shows that individuals generally prefer potential partners who share their political leanings. In real dating contexts, both liberals and conservatives tend to seek partners who are like themselves, including sharing political values. This similarity-seeking behavior contributes to partisan sorting in romantic relationships over time, potentially reinforcing polarization across generations. Consistent with these trends, I

expected that participants would rate dating profiles aligned with their own political identity more favorably than profiles of the opposing party. I also included an Independent profile as a neutral or nonpartisan option, to see if it might be evaluated intermediately or positively by those reluctant to date someone explicitly partisan.

Second, the design tested the main effect of the priming conditions. Priming was expected to moderate the salience of political identity when viewing the dating profiles. Specifically, the stereotypical prime (Condition 2) was hypothesized to amplify partisan thinking and potentially lead to more polarized partner preferences, making participants more critical of an opposing-party profile and more favorable toward a same party profile. In contrast, the counter-stereotypical prime (Condition 3) was designed to counteract stereotypes and highlight common ground between parties, reducing the weight of political affiliation in evaluating partners, possibly making participants more open to the opposing party profile than they otherwise would be. The Control condition (Condition 1), which involved a neutral article unrelated to politics (the topic was national parks), established a baseline for comparison, representing responses in the absence of any political prime.

The between-subjects random assignment of primes created equivalent groups, enabling inferences about the effect of exposure to polarized vs. depolarized narratives on dating judgments. Randomization was implemented through the Qualtrics survey platform's randomizer function, which assigned each participant to read one of the three articles with equal probability.

The within-subject aspect strengthens the design by allowing each participant to serve as their own control when comparing reactions to different partner political identities. However, because participants' own political orientation could influence which profile is "in-group" vs. "out-group" for them, I recorded each participant's self-identified political affiliation at the end

of the survey. In analyses, I account for this by classifying each profile viewing as matching or mismatching the participant's identity, Democrat participant viewing a Democrat profile = in-group scenario, Democrat viewing Republican profile = out-group scenario. This approach enables examining interaction effects such as whether the priming condition moderates the intensity of in-group favoritism or out-group aversion in dating preferences.

Procedure

The experiment was administered online using the Qualtrics survey platform. Participants completed the study individually at a time and location of their choosing (remote online participation). The procedure involved the following sequence of phases: Priming Manipulation, Manipulation Check, Baseline Measures, Dating Profile Evaluations, and Post-Experiment Measures and Debriefing. The total participation time was approximately 15 minutes. A detailed step-by-step procedure is outlined below:

Priming Manipulation (Article Reading Task): To begin, participants were randomly assigned to read one of three article stimuli corresponding to their priming condition. Each article was presented as a one-page news or magazine-style article of approximately 3–5 paragraphs, accompanied by a headline and a byline from the fictitious “American Center for Political Unity (ACPU)” to enforce credibility. Participants were instructed to read the article carefully, as they would be asked some questions about it afterward. They could take as much time as needed, but a minimum display time (60 seconds) was enforced by Qualtrics to ensure the content was not skipped too quickly.

Condition 1 (Control) read a neutral article titled “*Exploring the Beauty of National Parks in the U.S.*” which discussed travel and nature and contained no political content or partisan cues. This control article was included to serve as a baseline for participants' dating

evaluations unswayed by political priming, and to ensure that any effects in the experimental groups are due to the political nature of those primes.

Condition 2 (Polarization-Reinforcing Prime) read an article titled “*Americans Divided: Few Shared Beliefs Across Party Lines.*” This piece emphasized the depth of political and cultural divisions between Democrats and Republicans in the U.S. It summarized a fictitious large survey finding that the two parties “disagree on almost everything” and even differ greatly in demographic profile and lifestyle preferences. For example, the article highlighted that Democrats tend to be younger, more likely non-religious and LGBTQ, where Republicans tend to be older, more religious, and have higher incomes. It also mentioned differences in everyday choices such as preferred music, grocery stores, and even coffee brands. A quote from a fabricated political psychologist warned that political identity has become a defining social fault line “making it harder to find common ground”. The overall tone of this prime was to reinforce partisan stereotypes and a sense of blatant contrast between the parties. I expected that reading this could make participants more vigilant about partisan identity and more likely to favor an in-group dating candidate and reject an out-group candidate.

Condition 3 (Depolarizing Counter-Stereotype Prime) read an article titled “*Americans United: Shared Values Across Party Lines.*” In contrast to the previous condition, this piece emphasized similarities and points of agreement between Democrats and Republicans. It was structured as a report from the same fictitious institute, citing a survey of Americans that found considerable overlap in values on key issues, keeping the priming materials as similar as possible. The article pointed out that while there are demographic tendencies, these differences were minor and “show more similarity than difference between the parties.” It also highlighted common lifestyle choices shared across party lines like enjoying similar music, shops, coffee,

that are often overlooked in the media. A quote from the same fictitious psychologist suggested that perceived division is exaggerated and that people “underestimate how much they still have in common”. The intent of this prime was to provide a counter stereotypical perspective, effectively bridging the divide between the two parties. I expected that this depolarizing prime would decrease the salience of partisan boundaries and possibly lead participants to evaluate an out-party dating profile more open mindedly.

Manipulation Check: Immediately after the article, participants completed a brief manipulation check to assess whether they processed the prime as intended. Participants were shown an item inquiring “What was the main idea of the article you just read?” with answer choices listed as National Parks, Political Division, and Political Unity respectively. If necessary, I planned to exclude participants who failed to recall the article’s content to ensure data quality and that the prime was actually experienced.

Baseline Survey: After priming and a brief manipulation check, participants first answered a set of baseline questions assessing their existing attitudes toward political groups and dating preferences. This section included measures of affective polarization, political identity importance, and general dating criteria.

I used a broad set of measures to capture participants’ political attitudes, personality factors, and responses to the dating profiles. Whenever possible, I relied on preexisting scales from prior research, adapting them to the context. Below I detail each measure:

- *Affective Polarization:* I measured affective polarization using feeling thermometers and related items commonly used in political psychology. Participants were asked to rate, on a 0–100 scale, how “warm or cold” they feel toward (a) members of the opposing political party and (b) members of their own political party. These feeling

thermometer items are standard in polarization research (Iyengar et al., 2019) and provide a nuanced measure of partisan affect. Higher scores indicate warmer, more positive, feelings. I anticipated that most participants would give warmer ratings to their in-group and colder ratings to the out-group. In addition, I included Likert-type questions to gauge attitudes reflecting social distance and bias. I also asked about comfort with close relationships across party lines, such as “How comfortable would you be if a close family member married someone from the opposing political party?” (1 = Not at all comfortable, 5 = Extremely comfortable) and “Would you be comfortable being close friends with someone who strongly identifies with the opposing political party?” (1 = Extremely uncomfortable, 5 = Extremely comfortable). These items were drawn from prior studies on partisan prejudice; for instance, Iyengar and Westwood (2015) used similar questions to illustrate the rising unwillingness to inter-marry across party lines in the U.S. Collectively, these measures give a baseline of each participant’s partisan affect and bias.

- *Political Identity Strength:* I assessed how strongly each participant identifies with their political affiliation. I used items inspired by Huddy et al.’s (2015) work on expressive partisanship and social identity theory. One item stated, “My political identification (being a Democrat, Republican, Independent) is an important part of my identity.” Participants rated agreement on a 5-point scale. Another item, “My political beliefs guide my daily decisions.” (1 = Strongly Disagree, 5 = Strongly Agree), drawn from Levendusky (2018) who examined the influence of partisan versus national identity. These measures capture different aspects, the first being the psychological importance of party identity, and the second gauges behavioral

relevance. High scores on these indicate a strong political identity. I also recorded each participant's self-reported party affiliation (Democrat/Republican/Independent) and the strength of their political identity (Very conservative/Conservative/Moderate/Liberal/Very liberal) which are crucial measures for classifying in-group/out-group in this study.

I felt it was important to prime my participants before this information was collected because I didn't want to give away the true nature of the experiment and possibly lead participants to respond in a biased manner. Participants were shown a series of temperature gages (ranging from 1 – very cold to 100 – very warm) asking them how warm (positively) or cold (negatively) they feel towards opposing party members in different scenarios.

Dating Profile Presentation: After the baseline measures, participants were transitioned to the “dating profiles” section. They were told, “You will now view a series of profiles, similar to what you might see on a typical dating app. You will then answer a series of questions about these profiles. Please take your time to read each profile carefully. There are no right or wrong answers- we just wish to hear your opinion.” Participants were not explicitly alerted that these profiles were tied to the study's political theme, aside from the fact that each profile did list a political affiliation in its details. The profiles were presented one at a time, in random order for each participant, using Qualtrics' randomization for the block of profiles. Each profile consisted of a name, age, location, political affiliation, and a short bio with interests and a fun fact. I developed three realistic but fictitious profiles, intended to be comparable in overall attractiveness and differing primarily in the political affiliation label. The names selected were intended to be gender neutral as to appeal to both male and female participants. Images were not

presented as I felt they would skew the true purpose of the experiment and lead to inaccurate findings.

Profile A (Republican) –

Name: Jesse

Age: 22

Location: Avon, NY

Political Affiliation: Republican.

Bio: Weekend warrior who loves tailgates, cooking, and long drives through the countryside. I work in marketing, but my hearts in the outdoors.

Interests: Camping, music, Sunday with family.

Fun Fact: I've been to 32 states and counting. Next stop: Yellowstone, Wyoming.

This profile subtly invokes a few culturally conservative-leaning hobbies like football and road trips, though nothing overtly political beyond the affiliation label.

Profile B (Democrat) –

Name: Taylor

Age: 22

Location: Littleville, NY

Political Affiliation: Democrat

Bio: I'm a laid-back person who enjoys watching great TV shows with my favorite people.

Spending time with my family and friends is very important to me.

Interests: Netflix, music festivals, a day at the beach.

Fun Fact: When I was young, I dreamed of becoming an author. I still hope to finish my brilliant book.

This profile has a slightly different feel, interest in music festivals and a creative aspiration, but was intended to be equally likable and not explicitly political aside from the party label.

Profile C (Independent) –

Name: Alex

Age: 22

Location: Rush, NY

Political Affiliation: Independent.

Bio: I'm into live music and road trips with no specific destination. I'm excited about meeting new people, and I'm looking for fun and interesting conversations.

Interests: Skiing, cooking, podcasts.

Fun Fact: During the last solar eclipse, I drove 3 hours to get a great view from the middle of a field.

This profile was designed to be politically neutral; the interests are eclectic and not strongly stereotyped to either party.

All three profiles were kept constant in age and similar in general attractiveness of content. I deliberately chose names that are relatively gender-neutral, and I did not include profile photos to mask gender, predicting participants will assume the person is of the opposite gender. This was done to avoid confounding the results with gender and physical attractiveness differences, since participants of different sexual orientations might respond differently if they perceived a profile as male or female, I left gender ambiguous and focused their attention on the written attributes. Participants were instructed to assume each profile represents a potential

partner they might consider. By controlling the profiles in this manner, I aimed to isolate reactions to the political affiliation cue embedded in each profile.

Profile Evaluation Questions: After viewing each profile, participants answered a set of questions about their reactions to that profile. These questions served as the dependent measures of romantic interest and person perception. The same questions were asked for Profile A, Profile B, and Profile C. The questions were presented on the same page as the profile for easy reference. The evaluated dimensions included:

1. Attractiveness: “How attractive do you find this person?” rated on a 5-point scale (1 = Not at all attractive, 5 = Extremely attractive). This item allowed the participant to indicate their overall attraction to the profile owner.
2. Dating Interest: “How likely would you be to message this person on a dating app?” on a 5-point likelihood scale (1 = Not at all likely, 5 = Very likely). This gauges initial romantic interest or pursuit intention, higher scores mean they would be interested enough to initiate contact.
3. Perceived Compatibility: “How compatible do you think you are with this person?” on a 5-point scale (1 = Not at all compatible, 5 = Very compatible). This item captures the participant’s perception of shared interests or values with the person, essentially whether they think they would get along well. I included it because similarity is a key mediator of attraction according to Byrne’s (1971) Similarity and Liking hypothesis.
4. Willingness to Date: “Would you consider going on a date with this person?” on a 5-point scale (1 = Not at all willing, 5 = Very willing). This categorical measure is a behavioral intention indicator. It forces a choice on whether the participant would in principle accept this person for a date.

After answering these questions for the first profile, the survey automatically proceeded to show the next profile. The process repeated until all three profiles had been evaluated in this manner. By the end of this section, each participant had provided a set of ratings for each of the three target individuals. The random ordering ensures that any sequence effects are averaged out across participants. I also programmed the survey such that the profiles were labeled simply with the person's details, participants were likely to notice the political affiliation in each, but I did not draw extra attention to it in the instructions so as to observe natural effects of that detail.

Post-Experiment Measures: Following the profile evaluations, participants answered a series of post experiment questions intended to gauge changes in their attitudes and to serve as additional dependent measures related to the hypotheses. These questions explicitly asked participants to reflect on the role of politics in dating after having completed the profile review task. Key post experiment items included:

1. Importance of Politics in Dating: "How important is political alignment for you when selecting a romantic partner?" scaled 1 to 5, where 1 = "Extremely unimportant" and 5 = "Extremely important" with 3 = "Neither unimportant nor important" This item asked participants to self-assess if their viewpoint shifted. A response above 3 indicates that the experience (prime + seeing profiles) made them think political alignment is more important in partner selection than they initially did, while a response below 3 indicates it's less important now. I included this to capture any conscious re-evaluation by the participant. For example, a participant in the depolarizing condition might realize they could get along with an out-party person and rate politics as less crucial to compatibility now.

2. Openness to Dating Across Party Lines: “How likely are you to date a person with opposing political beliefs?” on a 1–5 scale (1 = Extremely unlikely, 3 = Neither likely nor unlikely, 5 = Extremely likely). This directly addresses the central question of whether the interventions changed willingness to date across party lines. Higher scores above 3 mean the participant feels more open minded to the idea of dating someone from the opposite party than they felt initially. I expected that participants in the depolarization prime condition might report greater openness, whereas those in the polarization prime might report being even less open to cross-party dating than before.
3. Deal Breakers: “Which of the following are deal breakers in a romantic partner? (select all that apply)” Choices included = Political affiliation, Religion, Education level, Career, Not getting along with family or friends. This item serves as a way of indicating the salience of political affiliation in participants judgement, giving researchers a baseline of other core values to compare the weight of political affiliation against. After asking for participants self-proclaimed political identity at the end of the survey, it also yields insight into what core beliefs are more important to members of a certain party, or if they simply vary from person to person.

Open-Mindedness Scale: The study included an assessment of participants’ open-mindedness using the Open-Minded Cognition Scale (Price et al., 2015). This scale was incorporated as a potential moderating variable to explore whether individual differences in cognitive openness might buffer the effects of political priming on romantic partner evaluations. Prior research suggests that open-minded individuals may be more willing to engage with divergent viewpoints and less likely to engage in polarized thinking (Price et al., 2015), making it a potentially relevant factor in the context of political identity and romantic preference.

Participants responded to four items from the short form of the Open-Minded Cognition Scale, each rated on a 5-point Likert scale (1 = Strongly Disagree, 5= Strongly Agree). The items included: “I enjoy engaging with people who have different perspectives from me,” “I actively seek out conversations with people whose opinions differ from mine,” “It is important to me to understand opposing viewpoints,” and “I try to consider all sides of an issue before forming an opinion.” This measure allowed for examination of whether open-mindedness moderated participants’ responses to dating profiles of politically aligned versus misaligned partners across the three priming conditions. Specifically, it enabled testing whether individuals with higher open-mindedness would exhibit reduced political bias in profile evaluations, potentially showing greater willingness to date across party lines even when exposed to polarization-reinforcing primes.

Debriefing: After completing all measures, participants were shown a debrief page. The debrief thanked them for their participation and explained the study’s purpose more in depth. It informed them that the articles were part of an experiment to prime certain mindsets about political differences, and that the dating profiles were fictitious and intentionally differed by political affiliation to examine how that affects partner preference. Contact information for the principal investigator and IRB was provided in case they had further questions or concerns. I also reiterated that their data would remain confidential and that they could withdraw their data if they felt uncomfortable. Finally, participants were given their Sona credit upon completion of the study.

Results

Data Cleaning

To begin, I examined whether some participants rushed through or lingered on for too long in the survey. The original data included a total of 118 participants. For the full sample, the average participation took about 934.5 seconds, ranging from 35 seconds to 48781 seconds. Using SPSS's outlier detection procedure, I removed participants who took longer than 15 minutes or shorter than 3 minutes, leaving us with 81 participants. Next, I examined the manipulation check. As can be seen in Table 1, 11 participants who read about national parks erroneously claimed they had read an article about politics (10 about political division, one about political unity). Since the National Parks article had no mention of politics in it, I removed these 11 from further analyses. Similarly, I removed two participants who had read the Political Division article, but chose National Parks. Since it is plausible to argue that an article about political unity is also about division (in the sense that it emphasizes division is not as bad as people thought), I did not remove those in the political conditions as long as they chose one of the political options. Finally, one person was removed as they skipped the manipulation check. The final data for analysis consisted of 67 participants. Because most omissions were from the control condition, the groups were not balanced, where only 14 read the national parks condition, 24 the stereotypical article, and 29 the counter-stereotypical article.

Table 1. Manipulation check

<u>Choice</u> <u>Condition</u>	<u>National Parks</u>	<u>Political division</u>	<u>Political unity</u>
<u>National Parks</u>	14	10	1
<u>Stereotypical</u>	2	21	3
<u>Counter-stereotypical</u>	0	15	14

Descriptive Statistics

Among the participants in the final analysis, the average time to complete the study was 371 seconds (median = 353, SD = 147.17). Warmth towards one's own party was on average higher ($M = 65.04$, $SD = 16.79$) than warmth towards the opposing party ($M = 42.45$, $SD = 16.74$). On average, people perceived the opposition as somewhat different than people from their own party ($M = 3.58$, $SD = 0.92$); felt somewhat comfortable with a close family member marrying a person from the opposing party ($M = 3.13$, $SD = 1.18$) and somewhat comfortable with having a close friend from the opposing party ($M = 3.20$, $SD = 1.27$); their political identity was neither important nor unimportant to them ($M = 2.71$, $SD = 1.13$) as was its impact on their daily activities ($M = 2.58$, $SD = 1.14$); when it comes to romantic partners, political ideology was on average somewhat important to participants ($M = 3.07$, $SD = 1.36$); participants found interaction with people with different perspectives somewhat enjoyable ($M = 3.59$, $SD = .85$); they neither sought nor did they avoid seeking conversations with people of different opinions ($M = 2.85$, $SD = 1.18$); they believed understanding people with opposing views to be important ($M = 4.13$, $SD = .99$); and reported trying to consider all sides of an issue before forming an opinion ($M = 4.31$, $SD = .74$). Finally, as for the main dependent variable, people were neither positive nor negative about dating people from an opposing political party ($M = 2.76$, $SD = 1.12$). When asked what would be considered a deal breaker, 21 participants chose political affiliation (multiple choices were allowed). Finally, 25 identified as Independents, 22 as Democrats, and 20 as Republican. The sample was slightly more liberal than conservative ($M = 3.04$, $SD = .96$, on a 5 point scale, with 1 being Very conservative and 5 being Very liberal).

Next, I created the “openness to the other side” variable, consisting of enjoyment in engaging with people of different perspectives, seeking conversations with people who have opposing views, importance of understanding people with different perspectives, and importance of considering all sides of an argument. The Cronbach alpha was adequate ($\alpha = .70$). The average openness score was 3.72 ($SD = .69$).

The correlation table for the main variables of interest can be seen in Figure 1 below.

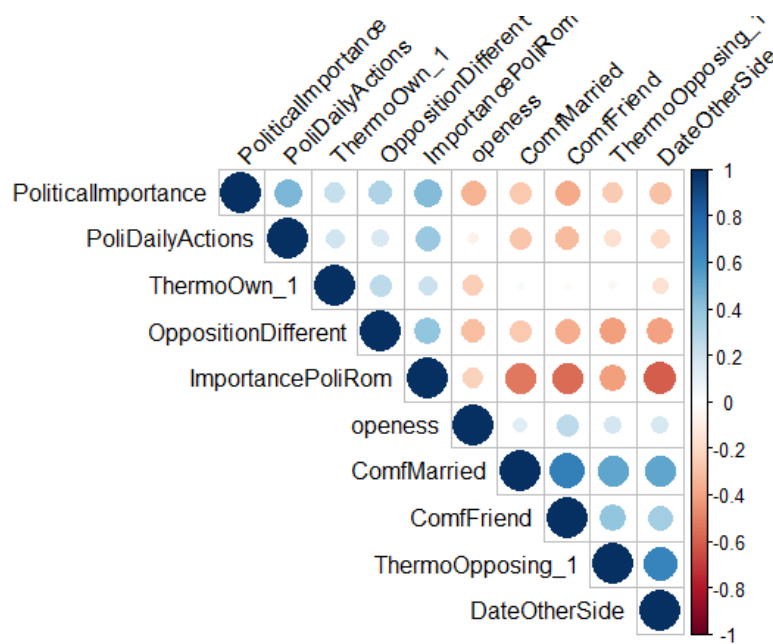


Figure 1. Correlation matrix.

Hypotheses Testing

All hypotheses were tested using an Analysis of Variance (ANOVA). The first hypotheses predicted that people will rate politically aligned partners as more attractive and compatible than misaligned partners (H1). First, I looked at how attractive participants found each dating profile. For Jesse, a Republican, party identity significantly predicted perceived attractiveness ($F(2, 64) = 7.65, p < .05$). A post-hoc Tukey comparison showed that Democrats

and Independents did not differ on that variable. Republicans ($M = 3.25$, $SD = 1.16$) found Jesse more attractive than Independents ($M = 2.40$, $SD = 1.00$) and Democrats ($M = 2.04$, $SD = .89$), and these differences were significant ($p < .05$). For Taylor, the Democrat, there was no significant difference ($F(2, 64) = 2.20$, $p > .05$) between Republicans ($M = 2.95$, $SD = 1.14$), Independents ($M = 3.12$, $SD = .66$), and Democrats ($M = 3.04$, $SD = .84$). For Alex, the Independent, there was a significant difference across parties ($F(2, 64) = 3.73$, $p < .05$). Only the difference between Republicans ($M = 2.40$, $SD = .99$) and Democrats ($M = 3.22$, $SD = 1.06$) was significant. The differences from Independents ($M = 2.64$, $SD = .99$) were not significant ($p > .05$).

Next, I examined intention to message each dating profile owner. For Jesse, the Republican, party had a significant effect ($F(2, 64) = 7.94$, $p < .05$). The difference between Republicans ($M = 3.05$, $SD = 1.27$) and Democrats ($M = 1.63$, $SD = .95$) was significant ($p < .05$) and the difference between Republicans and Independents ($M = 2.24$, $SD = 1.20$) was marginally significant ($p = .05$). The difference between Democrats and Independents was not significant ($p > .05$). For Taylor, the Democrat, the effect of party was not significant ($F(2, 64) = .58$, $p > .05$). with no differences between Republicans ($M = 2.60$, $SD = 1.23$), Independents ($M = 2.96$, $SD = .84$) and Democrats ($M = 2.77$, $SD = 1.26$). Finally, for Alex, the Independent, the effect of party was significant ($F(2,64) = 3.24$, $p < .05$). Republicans were less likely to message Alex ($M = 2.15$, $SD = 1.08$) than Democrats ($M = 3.04$, $SD = 1.17$), but the differences from Independent participants ($M = 2.48$, $SD = 1.19$) were not significant for both parties ($p > .05$).

Next, I examined perceived compatibility with each dating profile. For Jesse, the Republican, the effect of party was significant ($F(2, 64) = 10.92$, $p < .05$). Republicans ($M = 3.30$, $SD = 1.03$) perceived Jesse to be more compatible than Independents ($M = 2.44$, $SD =$

1.00) and Democrats ($M = 1.90$, $SD = .86$). The difference between Democrats and Independents was not significant ($p > .05$). For Taylor, the Democrat, the effect of party was not significant ($F(2, 64) = 2.08$, $p > .05$). The differences between Republicans ($M = 2.75$, $SD = 1.11$), Independents ($M = 3.32$, $SD = .74$), and Democrats ($M = 2.90$, $SD = 1.06$) were not significant ($p > .05$). Lastly, for Alex, the Independent, the effect of party was not significant ($F(2, 64) = .98$, $p > .05$), with no significant differences between Republicans ($M = 2.50$, $SD = 1.14$), Independents ($M = 2.56$, $SD = 1.08$), and Democrats ($M = 2.90$, $SD = .86$).

Finally, I examined likelihood to approach the potential profile owner for a date. For Jesse, the Republican, the effect of party was significant ($F(2, 64) = 7.11$, $p < .05$). Republicans ($M = 3.10$, $SD = 1.37$) were significantly different from Democrats ($M = 1.18$, $SD = 1.00$) and from Independents ($M = 2.20$, $SD = 1.00$). Democrats and Independents were not significantly different from one another ($p > .05$). For Taylor, the Democrat, the effect of party was not significant ($F(2, 64) = 1.29$, $p > .05$). There was no significant difference between Republicans ($M = 2.55$, $SD = 1.27$), Independents ($M = 3.04$, $SD = .97$), and Democrats ($M = 2.59$, $SD = 1.22$). For Alex, the Independent, the effect of party was not significant ($F(2, 64) = 1.692$, $p > .05$). No differences were found between Republicans ($M = 2.90$, $SD = 1.14$), Independents ($M = 2.56$, $SD = 1.08$), and Democrats ($M = 2.90$, $SD = .86$).

Taken together, H1 was partially supported, as party did affect perceptions and intentions in some, but not all cases.

H2 and H3 asked whether exposure to different priming articles will change political bias in partner selection compared to the control condition. First, I tested the effect on warmth towards one's own and opposing party. I created a new variable calculating the difference between how one feels about their own party and how they feel about the opposing party (i.e.,

Diff = own – opposing). Participants reported more positive feelings (warmer) when evaluating their own party than the opposing party, and the difference, on average, was 22.58 points (out of 100). As expected, the counter-stereotypical priming condition yielded the smallest gap between evaluating one's own and the opposing party ($M = 17.89$, SD), and this was significantly different from the wider gap among people in the control condition ($M = 38.15$, $SD = 28.28$). The differences between the stereotypical condition ($M = 19.69$, $SD = 22.81$) and other conditions were not significant ($p > .05$).

Next, I examined the effect of priming on feeling comfortable with a friend being from the opposing political party, and a close friend marrying someone from the opposing party (Cronbach alpha = .82, $M = 3.26$, $SD = 1.13$). There were no significant differences among any of the conditions ($F(2, 64) = 2.44$, $p > .05$), the control ($M = 2.67$, $SD = .91$), the stereotypical priming ($M = 3.41$, $SD = 1.04$), or the counter-stereotypical priming ($M = 3.41$, $SD = 1.23$). Finally, as for intention to date someone from the opposing party, there were no significant differences ($F(2, 64) = 1.69$, $p > .05$) between the control ($M = 2.28$, $SD = 1.06$), the stereotypical priming ($M = 2.95$, $SD = 1.16$), or the counter-stereotypical priming ($M = 2.82$, $SD = 1.10$). The counter stereotypical priming condition did reduce the gap in the evaluation of your own vs. other party member (compared to control), but there were no differences between groups when it came to feeling comfortable with your friends engaging or being from the other side, nor when it comes to intention to date the other side; H2 was partially supported, while H3 was rejected.

Ancillary Analyses

While not originally hypothesized in preparation for the experiment, I wanted to see if other psychological variables, including open-mindedness, comfortable feelings about friends

engaging or being from the other side, importance of political identity and how much politics affect one's daily actions (I tried creating a variable from the two identity questions, but the Cronbach alpha was inadequate, $\alpha = .62$, so I keep them separated in the model) in my data could predict the main outcome variables. For this purpose, I reran the analyses above as ANCOVAs, by adding potential covariates. When predicting the gap between evaluation of one's own and opposing parties, none of the covariates were significant ($p > .05$). The effect of conditions (counter-stereotypical vs. control) became only marginally significant holding these covariates ($p = .06$). When predicting intention to date a person from the other political side, feeling comfortable with a friend being from or marrying the other side, each had a significant effect ($B = .42$, $p < .05$). All other variables had no significant effect ($p > .05$). Finally, I added participants' party identity to the models. For the gap in evaluation, being an Independent reduced the gap (Democrats being the comparison group, $B = 19.69$), with no other variable being significant. As for intention to date the other side, political party did not have a significant effect ($p > .05$). As before, only the level of comfort variable was significant.

Discussion

The goal of this study was to evaluate the effects of media primes that either promote stereotypical or counter-stereotypical polarization on willingness to date people from the other side. The experimental findings provide support for the idea that political identity shapes romantic attraction. In line with the similarity-attraction paradigm, participants tended to evaluate dating profiles more favorably when there was political alignment. This was most prominent for the profile labeled Republican (Jesse): Republican-identifying participants rated this in-group profile significantly higher in perceived attractiveness, compatibility, and dating

intent than did Democrats or Independents (supporting H1). Conversely, Democratic and Independent participants showed low interest in the Republican profile, reflecting a strong aversion to this out-group partner. This pattern aligns with research on affective polarization showing that partisans prefer and feel more attracted to those who share their political beliefs. The results mirror tendencies to favor in-group members; political agreement boosted attraction, while a partisan mismatch, especially a Democrat viewing a Republican partner, depressed it. Such behavior is consistent with Social Identity Theory, which posits that individuals favor in-group members and can display hostility toward out-groups as a way of bolstering their own group identity. Furthermore, partisan identity can function like an in-group cue, leading people to root for their “home team” and reject the opposition. In the context of dating, this translated into clear in-group favoritism and out-group derogation on some measures, while other measures were unaffected.

Not all hypotheses were supported. H1 was only partially supported, as political alignment affected perceptions in some cases, but one notable exception was the Democrat profile, which did not elicit significant differences in ratings across participants’ party identities. In other words, unlike the Republican labeled profile, the profile labeled “Democrat” was rated similarly by Democrats, Republicans, and Independents (a null result contrary to expectations). I anticipated that Democratic participants would strongly favor the Democrat profile (in-group bias) and Republican participants might react negatively to it, but this did not occur. This unexpected null finding suggests that partisan bias in partner selection may be asymmetrical. Or there may have been something about the particular Democrat profile I crafted which was more attractive to participants. Democratic participants exhibited a strong out-group aversion, giving significantly low attractiveness and dating intention ratings to the Republican profile, yet

Republican participants did not show a correspondingly strong aversion to the Democrat profile. In fact, Republicans' evaluations of the Democrat profile were not significantly different from Democrats' own evaluations. This asymmetry (Democrats being more reluctant to consider a Republican partner than vice versa) is an interesting outcome of the study. My findings extend this idea, indicating the hostility may be more pronounced in one direction in the sample. One possible explanation is the current political landscape and sample characteristics; the college student sample (predominantly left-leaning) may perceive the Republican Party as especially opposing to their social values, amplifying Democrats' reluctance to date a Republican. Meanwhile, Republican identifying students might have been more familiar in interacting with Democrats, diminishing their opposition. As mentioned before, it is also possible that the specific content of the Democrat profile was attractive or relatable enough that even out-party viewers did not reject it, whereas the Republican profile may have activated stronger negative stereotypes among Democrat viewers.

The reaction to the Independent profile (Alex) further highlights the complexity of political identity in partner selection. Generally, profiles marked "Independent" received intermediate reactions, neither as warmly received as an in-group match nor as rejected as an out-group member in some cases. Democratic participants tended to rate the Independent profile quite favorably (in fact, Democrats found the Independent profile just as attractive as the Democrat profile in my study), suggesting that a politically neutral partner was seen as an acceptable or even positive alternative to an opposing-party partner. This could be because Independents are not associated with the disliked out-group's agenda, and Democrats might interpret an Independent as someone potentially sharing some of their values or at least not supporting the rival party. Republican participants, however, rated the Independent profile

significantly lower on some dimensions (attractiveness and messaging intent) than Democrats did. One interpretation is that Republican-identifying individuals in my sample may have viewed an Independent person with some skepticism, seeing them as lacking a clear affiliation or even suspecting them of leaning left, given the context. This asymmetry suggests that “Independent” may not be interpreted by participants as a neutral category, its perception can vary by the perceiver’s own identity. For the Republicans in a largely Democratic environment (a college campus), an Independent might not represent a true in-group or neutral ally, whereas for Democrats, an Independent was certainly preferable to a Republican. These distinctions suggest that political identity cues can shift attractiveness and compatibility judgments, but the direction of bias can depend on the observer’s standpoint. Importantly, I originally hoped to be able to test interactions between participants’ own party affiliation, the news story they’ve read, and the political affiliation of each profile on evaluations of attractiveness and dating probability. The sample size was too small to allow such analyses, thus forcing me to restrict the analysis to main effects only. As such, these explorations should be made in future studies.

Turning to the experimental priming manipulations, the results provided only limited support for hypotheses H2 and H3. I hypothesized that exposure to a polarization-reinforcing prime would exacerbate political bias in partner evaluations (H2), whereas exposure to a counter-stereotypical prime would weaken bias (H3). The data did not show a strong priming effect on the dating profile ratings themselves (though, again, the sample size was small, making it harder to identify significant effects); there were no significant effects indicating that the primes dramatically changed how participants rated in-groups vs. out-group nor that it affected openness to dating people from the other political side. Thus, H2 was not supported. Simply reading a polarizing article did not measurably increase discrimination against out-party dating prospects

beyond the baseline level. This could indicate a floor effect, participants may have already been polarized in their attitudes, leaving little room for a brief article to further heighten their reluctance to date a member of the opposing party. It is also possible that the polarization prime was not extreme enough to shift interpersonal judgments, or that its effects were short-lived.

On the other hand, I found partial evidence consistent with H3, the counter-stereotypical prime appeared to reduce partisan bias in some measures. Notably, participants who received the counter-stereotypical prime showed the smallest gap in feelings (warmth) between their own party and the opposing party, an average gap of 18 points on a 0-100 scale, compared to a much larger gap (38 points) among participants in the control condition. This difference was statistically significant, suggesting the counter-stereotype intervention successfully softened partisan affective polarization relative to no intervention. In contrast, the polarization-reinforcing prime group's feeling thermometer gap (20 points) was also smaller than the control group's, and not significantly different from the counter-stereotype group. In summary, both primes resulted in somewhat lower partisan affect gaps than the neutral condition, though only the counter-stereotypical prime differed significantly from control. The finding that the stereotypical prime reduced the gap compared to control (though not significant) is surprising. One interpretation is that simply prompting participants to reflect on politics (even through a polarizing article) made them more mindful of their attitudes, whereas the control group might have defaulted to more extreme affective reactions without any priming. More plausibly, this strange anomaly might be a result of the small sample; with limited statistical power, the priming effects were difficult to estimate reliably and may not reflect true differences. Due to data quality issues identified through the manipulation check, many participants were omitted from the control condition,

making this particular group especially small in size. This may have introduced statistical noise to the data. Future studies should replicate our findings with bigger, more representative sample.

Regardless, the fact that the counter-stereotypical prime produced the narrowest own-party vs. other-party gap aligns with H3's prediction and with theories of prejudice reduction. The findings hesitantly suggest that even in the charged space of dating preferences, exposure to counter-stereotypical information might open people's minds, at least in terms of general attitudes toward the opposing party. However, this did not completely translate into behavioral intentions like willingness to date out-party individuals in the study. It may be that changing abstract feelings is easier than changing actual romantic intentions. To conclude, the priming experiment yielded promising but limited results; the counter-stereotypical prime had a debiasing effect on partisan attitudes (partially supporting H3), whereas the polarization prime failed to produce the expected increase in bias (contradicting H2). These findings resonate with broader evidence that reducing affective polarization is challenging but possible. My study adds that such strategies might need to be quite salient or repeated to influence actual partner selection behavior, given that brief exposure produced only minimal shifts.

Limitations

Despite its contributions, this study has several limitations that hinder the interpretations of the findings and potential generalizability into the broader population. Some participants did not fully engage with the experimental materials, raising concerns about response quality. I observed large variance in the time taken to complete the survey and inconsistent responses on attention check questions, suggesting that a number of participants rushed or paid insufficient attention to the study. Analysis of the manipulation check indicated many participants did not correctly recall the prime content as intended, especially in the control condition, which was interpreted by many

as political. Low quality attention could have limited the true effects of the priming manipulation, if participants skimmed or failed to process the polarization or counter-stereotypical articles, the primes would not have the desired impact on their judgments.

Importantly the sample was made of undergraduate students, who may, on average, be less interested in politics. This is a relatively narrow demographic, mostly young adults in their late teens or early twenties, drawn from a similar geographic region and educational context. College students tend to have unique social and political profiles, for instance, they may be more liberal-leaning on average, less likely to be married or seeking long-term commitment at this stage, and potentially less polarized in some respects (or differently polarized, focusing more on social issues). They are also highly homogeneous in age and life experience. As a result, the dynamics observed here might differ in older or more diverse populations. Additionally, the student sample's political interest level may be variable; some participants might not strongly identify with any party, so their behavior might not mirror that of committed partisans in the general population. The findings pertain primarily to a college-educated U.S. youth context and should not be overgeneralized to all Americans. Future studies should include broader demographics to see if the same patterns hold among older adults, people in different regions or educational backgrounds, or those with firmer political identities.

All resulted in an underpowered analysis, that may yield Type II errors. Future research should address this by improving the size and representativeness of the sample, while finding ways to better engage participants with the experimental materials. Moreover, the imbalance in partisan groups can skew results. The Republican subsample was very small, making their mean ratings less reliable and increasing the uncertainty of any comparisons involving that group. Thus, some of the unexpected findings (or lack of expected ones) may simply be due to who

enrolled in the study. A larger, more balanced sample (ensuring adequate numbers of Democrats, Republicans, and Independents) would provide a more robust test of the hypotheses.

Unfortunately, the small and uneven sample prevented me from analyzing some of the potential interactions between participants' traits, priming stories, and dating profiles. As discussed earlier, the design aimed to test not just main effects of priming or political identity but their interaction (whether the priming effects were different for Democrats versus Republicans, or whether the influence of political alignment on attraction was mitigated by certain primes). In analysis, I severely lacked sufficient data to reliably examine these nuanced questions. For instance, an ideal test of H2 and H3 would look at the difference in in-group vs out-group attraction for each prime condition, essentially a three-way interaction (participant party x profile party x prime). The sample size used for final analyses ($N = 67$) was far below what is needed for such a complex ANOVA to have adequate power. As a consequence, I could not reliably estimate whether any observed trends were statistically significant or whether different subgroups reacted to the primes differently. This limitation means I must be cautious in interpreting the study's results, but the absence of significant interactions does not prove the primes had no effect; it might simply mean the study was not sensitive enough to detect them. Similarly, I could not deeply explore moderation by individual differences such as strength of partisan identity or openness to dating across lines, factors that might play an important role but require a larger sample or a targeted design. In future research, a higher-powered study should be used to test these interactions. By doing so, one could uncover, if only strongly identified partisans react adversely to polarization primes, or if the counter-stereotype prime mainly helps those who were initially moderate in their biases. My study provides a blueprint, but a larger sample is needed to fully map the moderation landscape.

Finally, it should be noted that experimental realism (external validity) is a potential limitation. Participants knew they were rating hypothetical profiles in a survey context, which is a step removed from real-life dating behavior. Some might not have taken the scenario as seriously as they would actual dating app interactions. Others might have responded in a socially desirable way (a Republican participant rating a Democrat profile kindly to appear open-minded, even if in real life they would swipe left). Thus, there is a concern about whether stated intentions in an experiment translate into real world choices. While my design tried to emulate a dating app format and ensure anonymity to encourage honesty, this limitation is inherent in survey experiments and should be addressed by future studies possibly incorporating more immersive or behavioral measures.

Implications

Despite the above limitations, the findings carry several noteworthy implications for understanding polarized dating preferences and for addressing the challenges of political polarization in personal relationships. The results highlight how deeply polarization has seeped into the structure of everyday life, even the search for love. That young people would discount a potential partner merely for belonging to the “wrong” political party highlights the widening social divide between partisan groups. This mirrors broader trends, Americans are increasingly separated by politics not just in their media and neighborhoods, but in their interpersonal relationships. The study’s outcome, that most participants gravitated toward politically similar partners, helps explain why politically mixed relationships are now so scarce. When Democrats overwhelmingly partner with Democrats (and Republicans with Republicans), households become politically uniform, children are raised in one sided political environments, and cross-

cutting dialogue or introspection prompted from a politically dissimilar other diminishes or ceases to exist.

This romantic sorting by party likely reinforces affective polarization over time; if one rarely breaks bread or builds a life with someone of the opposite party, the “other side” remains a distant out-group, easily ridiculed and demonized. The interpersonal segregation I observed in the present study may be both a product of and a contributing factor to the macro-level partisan hostility in America. The fact that many participants, especially Democrats, in this study were unwilling to even consider an opposite-party match suggests that political differences are becoming a fundamental deal breaker similar to differences in core values or religion. This has profound implications for social cohesion, as fewer interparty relationships mean fewer opportunities for empathy and understanding across the divide. It is consistent with the idea that affective polarization can create parallel social universes, where members of each party view the other as nearly incompatible with their way of life.

Given that political identity influences dating choices, there are potential applications for dating apps and other services to address this polarization. Many dating apps already allow users to filter matches by political preference or display a person’s politics on their profile. The findings suggest that such features, while catering to user preferences, may further isolate individuals and prevent potentially positive matches across party lines. One implication is that apps might consider counter-polarization features. For instance, rather than prominently labeling profiles by party (which might trigger immediate rejection, as I saw in the experiment), an app could highlight commonalities first, letting users see shared interests, values, or hobbies before revealing political affiliation. By the time political differences surface, there might already be some personal rapport or attraction established, making users less likely to dismiss each other

outright. A dating app could take a page from these findings by, for instance, running a campaign that highlights real couples or friendships across the aisle to inspire users and normalize cross-party connections. In summary, while it may seem high-tech or unconventional, integrating counter-stereotypical and depolarizing cues into matchmaking services or media could be a novel frontier in combating affective polarization. If done carefully, this might not only expand individuals' dating pools but also foster greater interpersonal understanding across party lines, leading to greater social cohesion. Even modest success in getting people to interact romantically or socially with someone of the opposite party can humanize that out-group and reduce the toxic us vs. them mentality.

This study opens several avenues for future inquiry. First, replicating and extending these findings with larger, more diverse samples is a required next step. A study with a nationally representative sample could determine whether the patterns I observed are general phenomena or specific to younger college students. It would be especially valuable to see if the asymmetry I found, Democrats' greater aversion to out-party dating, holds in a broader population or whether Republicans in other contexts are equally averse. Second, more complex designs could investigate the mechanisms behind the priming effects and further test interventions. Future research should investigate moderators of these effects; are there individual differences that predict who is open to cross-partisan romance? Perhaps personality traits like openness to experience, need for cognitive closure, or strength of partisan identity will influence how much political cues sway one's attraction. The data hinted that some participants were not as affected by the primes or the partisan labels; understanding these differences could help target interventions at those most biased. Finally, as political polarization continues to evolve, researchers might examine the role of media and dating algorithms in either reinforcing or

breaking down these patterns. For instance, do dating app algorithms inadvertently contribute to political homophily by matching people who are socially similar (and often politically similar)? And could tweaking those algorithms to introduce more political diversity in matches have positive effects, or would it backfire? These are empirical questions worth exploring. By pursuing these lines of inquiry, future studies can build on these findings to not only document the influence of politics on partner choice but also guide solutions for bridging the partisan divide in our love lives.

Conclusion

Political polarization has become a determining factor in American society, influencing public discourse, policymaking, and personal relationships. This study aims to highlight the importance of political identity in romantic partner preference, focusing on the roles that stereotypes, affective polarization, and priming play in shaping attraction. By investigating these interactions, this research contributes to a growing body of literature that explores how political membership extends beyond the political sphere and into the personal domain of romantic decision-making.

The findings of this study shed additional light on the broader societal implications of affective polarization. Previous literature has shown that stereotypes concerning political out-groups only contribute to misperceptions and deepen divides surrounding ideological differences (Ahler & Sood, 2018; Iyengar et al., 2019). These stereotypes severely limit the potential for inter-party contact and discourage the formation of relationships across political lines. By exploring the impact that priming has on partner preference and selection, and testing the

effectiveness of counter-stereotypical interventions, this research seeks to pinpoint reasonable strategies for mitigating political biases in romantic contexts.

The study highlights the potential of counter-stereotypical interventions to reduce prejudice and create ideological tolerance. Drawing on frameworks from social disciplines, such as intergroup contact theory and prejudice reduction strategies (Hsieh et al., 2022; Paluck et al., 2021), this research shows the importance of creating an atmosphere where individuals can challenge the preconceived notions about political outgroups. In doing so, it aims to lessen the distance between political others and promote social cohesion in an increasingly polarized society.

In conclusion, this research offers a unique view of the consequences of political polarization. It investigates how political identity, stereotypes, and priming influence romantic partner preferences to uncover new avenues for bridging ideological divides in a world of increasing polarization. Ultimately, this work aims to contribute to a deeper understanding of how personal relationships can serve as a foundation for reducing societal divisions and building a more cohesive and compassionate world. While the insight gathered from the analysis was severely limited by the size and quality of the student data, I provide a blueprint for testing the effect of stereotypical and counter-stereotypical primes on dating preferences, which could guide future studies into this growingly important topic.

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